

STEVE CUMMINS

Principal / Chief Marketer, Solent Strategies • Fractional CMO, 20+ years B2B marketing

steve@solentstrategies.com • linkedin.com/in/stevecummins • applied Aug 28 • mentored two prior Uplift cohorts • found the LinkedIn post

PROPOSED SLOT

SESSION 7 • FRI SEPT 25 • 12:30 PM ET

His ranking: 7, then 8, then 3
Open to other dates: yes

TITLE

HIS

Marketing that Maps the Customer Journey

OURS, PLAIN AND DESCRIPTIVE

Marketing for Early-Stage Founders: Which Tactics Belong at Which Stage

WHAT FOUNDERS LEAVE WITH, IN THEIR WORDS

TAKEAWAY 1

Define the goal of your marketing, then match tactics to each stage

TAKEAWAY 2

What has to be in place before you spend: a clear message, a defined reachable audience

TAKEAWAY 3

Do one or two things well rather than covering every base

THE 30 MINUTES

Takes the classic marketing funnel and shows which tactics belong at which stage, then argues the customer journey is no longer linear so the old funnel needs a more nuanced read. Presentation with slides, questions at the end.

WHY IT MATTERS NOW, IN HIS WORDS

Every founder is told to do marketing and everyone they ask has an opinion, AEO, Google ads, social posting. Founders have no spare time and a small budget, so it matters where those go.

FORMAT

Presentation, then Q&A

AIMED AT

Pre-revenue testing the market, generating revenue, raising

BRINGS

A one-pager built for the session, plus an 8-page eBook, Building a Realistic Marketing Strategy

DECK

Yes, in Drive. Series: wants to talk it through.

SETTLE ON THE CALL

- Nothing blocking. Confirm the eBook can go in the cohort resource library with his name on it.
- Ask him to name the one or two tactics he would tell this cohort to pick, so the session ends on a decision.

RECOMMENDATION

GO

Recommend booking. Strongest of the four: concrete, has a real deck, brings usable resources, and marketing is a top-requested subject. Prior mentor, so he knows the room.

ERIC SCHMALZBAUER

Co-founder & CEO (now former), Prospective · the team behind the open-source Perspective project

eric.schmalzbauer@gmail.com · linkedin.com/in/ericschmalzbauer · applied Aug 31 · referred by you · also on the mentor list

PROPOSED SLOT

SESSION 2 · MON SEPT 14 · 12:30 PM ET

His ranking: 2, then 5, then 8
Open to other dates: yes

TITLE

HIS

B2B: from idea > funding > failure

OURS, PLAIN AND DESCRIPTIVE

Lessons From Winding Down a Venture-Backed B2B Startup

WHAT FOUNDERS LEAVE WITH, IN THEIR WORDS

TAKEAWAY 1

Tangible examples of what worked and what did not inside a venture-backed startup

TAKEAWAY 2

As a founder you always have to be selling, in some form

TAKEAWAY 3

Honest acknowledgement that the job is very lonely

THE 30 MINUTES

A first-time founder winding down a venture-backed company, in his own words: the arc from idea through fundraising and team building to deciding when and why to close; what he will change next time; what he will do more of. Fireside, so we interview him and founders ask questions. No deck needed.

WHY IT MATTERS NOW, IN HIS WORDS

Whatever stage a founder is at, the worries overlap: fundraising, team building, go-to-market, managing investors.

FORMAT

Fireside chat

AIMED AT

Any founder in the cohort

BRINGS

Workbench Ventures GTM Weekly newsletter

SERIES

Maybe. Ideas: GTM from scratch, and investor management.

SETTLE ON THE CALL

- How openly can he name numbers, timelines and the decision to close? The candour is the whole value, so agree the boundary before the day.
- Julia Kahky also proposed a shutdown post-mortem. Keep his on the founder and funding arc, hers on enterprise sales, and space them a week apart.
- Fireside means we need the questions. Ask him for the three he wishes someone had asked him at the start.

RECOMMENDATION

GO

Recommend booking. Founders hear success stories constantly and almost never a first-hand account of winding down. Fireside is the right format and needs no prep from him.

JULIA KAHKY

VP Operations, Tailsight • aviation software; formerly chief of staff, fintech and sports media operations

julia.m.kahky@gmail.com • linkedin.com/in/juliamkahky • applied Aug 28 • speaks to audiences regularly

PROPOSED SLOT

SESSION 5 • MON SEPT 21 • 12:30 PM ET

Her ranking: 2, then 5, then 4

Session 2 goes to Eric, so this is her second choice

TITLE

HERS

From startup to dissolution: a post-mortem

OURS, AND THE RENAME MATTERS

Selling Software to Enterprise and Regulated Customers: Lessons From a Startup That Closed

WHAT FOUNDERS LEAVE WITH, IN THEIR WORDS

TAKEAWAY 1

Problems to avoid early on

TAKEAWAY 2

Product-market fit

TAKEAWAY 3

Sales cycles

THE 30 MINUTES

Everything she learned trying to sell software to enterprise customers and into highly regulated markets, framed as a post-mortem of a company that did not make it. What worked, what did not. Presentation with slides.

WHY IT MATTERS NOW, IN HER WORDS

Everything online is about how companies succeed, and people learn more from the mistakes of companies that failed.

FORMAT

Presentation, then Q&A

AIMED AT

Selected every audience option

BRINGS

Her community, The Atrium; the post-mortem deck; a list of AI tools, tips and tricks

DECK LINK

Points to a podcast episode, not a deck

SETTLE ON THE CALL

- **Reframe the title.** Two shutdown post-mortems in one cohort is repetitive, and her real differentiator is enterprise and regulated sales. Same content, sharper promise.
- The three takeaways are topic labels rather than outcomes. Ask what a founder should do differently on Monday for each.
- She aimed at every stage at once. Push her to pick the two that fit best so the blurb has an edge.
- Get the actual deck, and confirm what The Atrium is before we put it in the resource library.

RECOMMENDATION

GO, IF SHE TAKES THE RENAME

Experienced speaker with real scar tissue in a lane nobody else offered. It only works billed as enterprise and regulated sales rather than a second failure story.

JEFFREY HANG

Senior Associate, Lair East Labs · and Head of Program, Pioneering Minds AI

jeffrey@pioneeringminds.ai · linkedin.com/in/jeffrey-ze-chong-hang · applied Aug 28 · found your LinkedIn post · speaks regularly

PROPOSED SLOT

SESSION 8 · MON SEPT 28 · 12:30 PM ET

His ranking: 8, then 11, then 14
Open to other dates: yes

TITLE

HIS, WHICH IS TWO SESSIONS

What do VCs look for / GTM in the Age of AI

OURS, PICK ONE

A. How Investors Evaluate Early-Stage Startups

B. Building a Go-to-Market Plan When AI Changes the Playbook

WHAT FOUNDERS LEAVE WITH, IN THEIR WORDS

TAKEAWAY 1

GTM strategies in the age of AI

TAKEAWAY 2

Executive storytelling

TAKEAWAY 3

Product design methodologies

THE 30 MINUTES

A working session where founders bring their own material and he coaches live. Stated scope: business model analysis, product design, pitch, go-to-market. He is a venture-side operator at a New York accelerator who works with early-stage founders on go-to-market, fundraising, positioning and growth.

WHY IT MATTERS NOW, IN HIS WORDS

The old playbook is not working as well in the age of AI, so founders need a framework to stand out.

FORMAT

Working session, coaches live

AIMED AT

Idea stage through raising, plus understanding investors

BRINGS

Individual comments and a GTM playbook

SERIES

Yes, up to three. Wants to iterate on decks and GTM with founders across sessions.

SETTLE ON THE CALL

- **One topic, not two.** The investor lens and GTM in the age of AI are separate sessions. Pick one for Session 8 and hold the other for the series.
- Thinnest application of the four: a four-word summary, no deck, takeaways written as phrases. Ask for the actual structure of the 30 minutes.
- A live teardown needs volunteers. Decide whether we pre-recruit two founders to bring work, or it will stall on the day.
- He is the only one who wants a series, so if the first lands he can fill three slots.

RECOMMENDATION

GO, ONCE SCOPED

Credentials and format are useful and the series upside is real, but nothing in the application says what actually happens in the room. Scope it on the call before the event page goes live.